

Matterhorn & Whorl

August 21st & 22nd, 2010

I picked up Keith Christensen and Ron Hudson on Long Beach and South Pasadena respectively and started the now weekly long drive north. The peaks this weekend were just inside the border of Yosemite National Park but our crafty leader Kathy Rich had decided to hike in via Twin Lakes above Bridgeport and make the crossing via Horse Creek Canyon and thereby avoid the park entrance fees and restrictions. Still there was going to be an extra hour or two of driving each way so we left early afternoon instead of my usual 8 pm.

We arrived at Twin lakes sometime after 11 pm with Ron asleep in the back and Keith and I struggling to stay awake up front. After eyeing the nearby campsites and finding them full we pulled into an area behind the lake technically marked as Day Use Only, laid out our sleeping pads in the dirt, and quickly passed out.

After the late night encounter a few weeks previous with feces throwing tow truck drivers I was somewhat nervous that we'd be rousted in the middle of the night but still managed to fall asleep rather quickly.



I awoke the next morning undisturbed and the three of us threw everything back into my vehicle and munched on our primitive breakfasts. It was then that we had visitors.



They sniffed around us and seemed about to take Keith's cereal right out of his hand but ended up just munching on a few nearby bushes.

We headed back for the main road and after a bit of difficulty managed to locate the actual trailhead and meet up with the rest of the group. We enacted the usual pre-hike Sierra Club paperwork rituals before shouldering our packs and starting up the trail.



The trail climbed but was easy on the feet compared to the last few weeks adventures. The weather was sunny and beautiful...



That is until we made it a few miles in. Suddenly the wind was blowing and darker clouds started flying by above us. So much for my good weather streak.



As we were climbing up the pass we were soon in a wind tunnel. At one point Kathy was hit by a gust and did get thrown over bruising her sternum. Wheee...



At the top of the pass we found a snow field pocketed by sun cups. We hurried over it hoping to find refuge from the cold wind on the far side.



6 miles from the car we crossed over into Spiller Canyon and things did improve a bit though the wind still slammed into us rather insistently. We all struggled to set up our tents and piled rocks inside and on the stakes in the hope they wouldn't blow away while we were gone.

As this was a two day two peak trip we still had a peak to make that day. The goal was Matterhorn an SPS Emblem peak which means it's the most dominant peak in the area.

At camp we ran into a pair of climbers who had attempted Whorl (the peak we'd be doing Sunday) and after failing to find the right chute had turned around and were heading for the cars.



We left up the slope towards Matterhorn. Disappointingly the route from the Spiller Canyon side is just a slog up loose sand and rocks.



We ran into another couple coming down the route who turned out to be the owners of the tent we had found pitched in the one and only relatively wind free spot down below. The guy was apparently one of the first PCT hikers though he's not the one they name in the books.

We continued up the loose crap (technical mountaineering term) and eventually reached the solid rock above.



Even then it didn't really stray above 2nd class but at least we weren't sliding down a step for every two we took.



We made the summit, grabbed the register ammo box, and quickly climbed down to a somewhat sheltered spot to get out of the wind. We didn't spend too long because as nice as the view was the wind was making things unpleasantly cold.



The descent went rather quickly as the loose dirt allowed us to slide down for a good portion.

Back in camp the tents were still standing but my Shire's Tarp Tent was just being slammed by wind to the point it was barely standing. I quickly came to the conclusion my initial location and orientation wasn't going to work and with some assistance re-pitched my tent elsewhere making sure the front flaps were facing into the wind. Now instead of being near collapse my tent was stretched out like a wind

sock. Progress!



Once the beak of my tent was closed I was actually fairly sheltered from the wind and the loud flapping of the tent material was somewhat drowned out by the earplugs that have been a part of my standard camping gear since my initial Sierra Club camping outing where I was situated next to someone who snored so loud the walls of the tent had vibrated. In comparison this was nothing.

We all went to bed early before the sun was down but once in our tents it was such a relief to be out of the wind no one was complaining.

I woke up at 5:15 am the next morning after a surprisingly restful night to find my tent still being battered by high winds. I'd actually slept through my 4:30 am alarm due to the background noise and had to scramble to get everything together for our 6 am departure.

Others had a somewhat less restful night and one person had failed to sleep at all and had decided to leave the trip early and hike out.



We still had fast moving clouds above us and today they were low enough to obscure the nearby ridges though fortunately the one we were headed for was still clear. It actually had the interesting effect as the sun came up of making it look like the eastern ridge was on fire. We appreciated the beauty as we hopped around in place trying to stay warm.



It was cold and we were all wearing most of the layers we had brought as we left camp. After all this was a summer backpack and light weight gear and minimal clothing was the rule.

We traversed to the southwest and started to climb the slopes below Whorl. Whorl was a mountaineering peak which means it requires some additional amount of actual skill as opposed to slogging up a sandy slope to get the peak. Soon we were moving up light 3rd class rocks.



Route finding proved to be the real challenge. The previous day we had encountered two separate groups that had been unable to locate the correct chute and had ended up turning back. The general consensus was they had headed up too early and we were eager to avoid the same mistake.



We climbed into a chute which we hoped was the one described in the peak guide and the climbing got into solid 3rd territory. After a short period of being unsure we were in the right chute we caught sight of the major landmark of the climb, the chock stone.



This was a rock wedged in to a pinch point. To climb around or over the top was 4th class (meaning a fall would be an extremely bad idea) but it was apparently possible to climb underneath.



Once inside there is a jumble of boulders which had just enough room to squirm through.

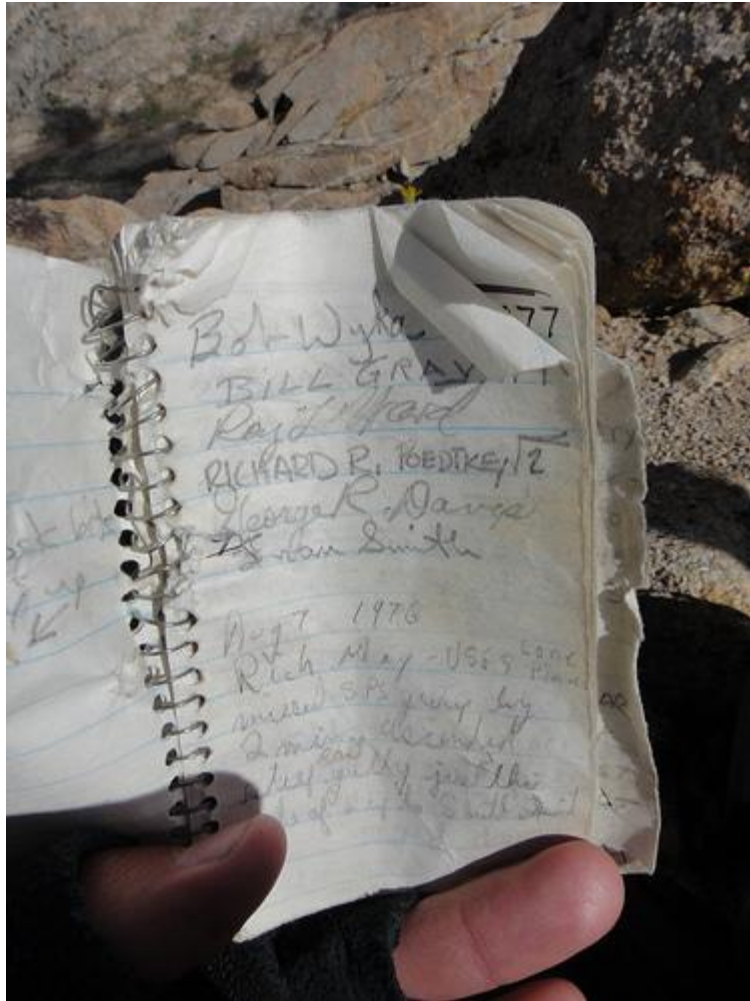


After about 15 vertical feet we emerged out the top and continued on to the summit. It was a rather memorable section unlike any other peak I've climbed before.



From there it was an easy stroll to the top as there was a well formed catwalk of sorts to follow.

We arrived and found a register canister containing multiple registers the oldest of which dated back to 1976.



It's always neat to look back on the signatures from before I was born. In addition there were a large number of sign-ins from what appeared to be a counseling group of some sort in the 80s. Treatment by climbing mountains!? Where do I sign up?



The weather had finally taken a turn for the better after a day and a half of wind and we were treated to sunlight and the slightest bit of warmth.



The view was also rather spectacular.

We spent a good amount of time on the summit but we still had to return to camp, pack up, and hike out so before long we were descending back along our route.



We were finally able to strip off the extra clothing layers which was a relief.



Back in camp it was still windy which made packing away my tent an exercise in frustration but soon we were heading back over the pass and descending.



Once we descended a ways down Horse Creek it was a relief to finally be free of the wind.



Kathy, Mary Joe, David, and Charles were all driving back to LA that night but Ron and Keith had elected to stay an extra day and join me for another mountaineering peak in Yosemite. After all, who wants to spend 14 hours driving for only two days of climbing?



We all had dinner at the Mobile station below Tioga Pass home to the famous Whoa Nellie Deli. Oddly enough we encountered Shawn and Laura who I had met at the Sierra Challenge the previous weekend. They were just coming back from having day hike Lyell and McClure, two peaks I'd done as a three day trip the year before. Considering the hike to the base of the glacier is ~14 miles each way and the climb from there can get rather technical my hat was off to them.

We finally bid adieu to the others and went off in search of a campsite for the night.

Full picture set:

<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157624670920305/>

Cathedral Peak

Mountaineers Route, 4th Class

August 23rd, 2010

We woke up with the sun and threw everything back in my Rav4 which strangely seemed to get more full the longer we were out. We then drove into Yosemite getting waved past the ranger shack at 7:59 less than a minute before fee collection time started. We'd catch them on the way out.

We drove through Tuolumne and parked at the Cathedral Lake trailhead. Getting out of the car we could see our peak off in the distance between the trees.



It actually looked rather intimidating from there.

The approach involved several miles down the JMT which we did at a brisk pace.



Then it came time to climb. After some very minor loose crap (again, official mountaineering term) we started on some beautiful steep slabs.



It was a bit of work climbing up directly but I had a blast. My partners were somewhat unenthusiastic about smiling for my camera for some reason.



I should point out Ron in the blue is actually 65 years old and in amazing shape. I have a hard time keeping up with him on cross country terrain.

We eventually reached a saddle between the actual summit and something called the Eichorn.



Apparently there's an easy 5.3 route up it and I was kicking myself for not bringing gear to climb it. Next time!



We instead turned toward the actual summit and climbed a solid 3rd / at times borderline 4th class route until we found ourselves below the summit block itself. From here things definitely get 4th class.

To climb to the actual summit you climb out onto a small slopped ledge that is dangling above a rather worrying drop. You inch across watching your footing very carefully and turn a corner to face a 15 foot crack. It's not a very difficult crack but the drop behind you means a fall is something you'll only do once.

I deferred to Ron's experience and we broke out his rope and I belayed him as he climbed across and up the crack.



Once he was up top he struggled to build an anchor and secure himself. Eventually he was relatively secure and after Keith tied into the other end with a bowline on a coil and Ron belayed him up.



After remaining up top for only a few minutes he down climbed back to where I was waiting and it was now my turn.



The climbing wasn't bad, while scouting ahead of the others I'd been partway up the crack without a rope but I was still very aware of the drop behind me. After a short scramble I was sitting up top next to Ron.



Here's what I climbed up and would soon be climbing down:



I discussed options with Ron and we decided he would belay me to the base of the crack at which point I'd belay him down. We were leaving a single sling up top and a carabineer which Ron had liberated from inside a crack. He came down and crossed back to the relatively safe area where Keith was waiting and once he was there I untied and followed.

After a brisk hike out the Budd Creek trail we reached the cars a little before 2 pm and started the long drive home.



We were actually waved through the ranger pay station again as we exited. I tried to tell the ranger we hadn't paid on the way in (much to Ron's consternation as he scolded me never to volunteer that information) but as they were a bit busy at the moment she insisted.

I made it back to Orange County after dropping off my two carpool mates at 9 pm. Not bad considering my usual habit of late night arrivals followed by catching very early flights the following mornings. I actually had several hours of sleep before having to wake up and head for the Orange County airport. I could almost get use to this except except heck, if I get home that early there's enough time for another peak!

Next week is an official trip I'm co-leading with Kathy to Dragon, Gould, and Kearsarge. Three peaks, two days, and one summit block with some rather notable exposure. But sadly first there are 4 days of work. Bleh.

Full picture set:

<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157624795682854/>

